

Ontology Interview: One-Page Field Guide

Purpose: capture how the domain works. Do not try to finish the ontology live. Record the meeting, take minimal structured notes, and classify carefully afterwards.

THINGS + PROPERTIES + RELATIONSHIPS + RULES + ACTIONS + RESULTS

Ask about real work first. Convert the answers into this structure later.

The six building blocks

Building block	Plain meaning	Reinforced concrete design	IT support operations
1. Things	Objects the agent must distinguish, retrieve, connect, or reason about.	Beam, Load, Material, Design Check	Incident, IT Service, Alert, Support Team
2. Properties	Values that describe one thing.	Beam width = 300 mm; Load magnitude = 45 kN	Incident priority = high; Service criticality = critical
3. Relationships	Meaningful connections between things, written as verb phrases.	Load acts on Beam; Beam uses Concrete Grade	Incident affects IT Service; Team supports Service
4. Rules / constraints	Conditions that determine whether something is valid, allowed, or required.	Design resistance must be at least the design action: $R_d \geq E_d$.	A critical incident affecting a critical service must be escalated.
5. Actions	What the agent can calculate, check, propose, update, or produce.	Calculate required reinforcement; check shear; propose a revised section.	Classify incident; assign team; notify service owner.
6. Results / states	The outcome of a check or action.	Pass/fail; utilisation = 0.82; warning; missing input.	Open/resolved; assigned/unassigned; SLA at risk; escalation sent.

Quick classification test

Make it a thing when: the agent must identify it separately, connect it to several things, or reason about it independently.

Make it a property when: it is mainly one descriptive value of another thing.

Do not ask: "Is this an entity?"

Ask: "Can it exist separately? Can several objects refer to it? What information describes it?"

Minimal interview progression

1. Pick one real workflow.
2. Ask for input -> work -> output.
3. Note important things and decisions.
4. Ask how the things connect.
5. Ask which facts change a decision.
6. Replay the workflow and ask what is wrong or missing.

Live note format: term | meaning | connected to | why the agent needs it | confirmed / unclear / disputed

Six exact questions to use

Things What must the agent identify or reason about separately?	Properties Which facts about it change a calculation, decision, or output?
Relationships How does this connect to the other things in the workflow?	Rules What must be true for this to pass, proceed, or be allowed?
Actions What should the agent calculate, check, propose, or produce?	Results How do we describe the outcome, and how is success verified?